

Word family: **background / backgrounds / backgrounded / backgrounding / foreground**

Base word: background

Plural: backgrounds

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / adjective used before nouns (定語用法) / occasionally verb (較少見)

Useful family extensions: foreground, background noise, background music, background information, background knowledge, background check, background process/app

Your sentence:

> “Then, as soon as they put the headphones on, everything seemed to fade into the **background**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **background** is figurative.

It means the less noticeable or less important part of someone's attention, rather than the main thing they are focusing on.

繁體中文: **注意力中較不突出、較不重要的位置; 某事仍然存在, 但不再成為主要焦點**

中文翻譯:

> “Then, as soon as they put the headphones on, everything seemed to fade into the background.”

「然後, 他們一戴上耳機, 周圍的一切似乎便逐漸**退居背景**, 不再那麼引人注意或干擾他們。」

fade into the background = 逐漸變得不顯眼、不再成為注意力焦點

1. **background = rear part of a scene/image (畫面／景象較後方部分) — 背景; 後景**

This is the central physical/visual meaning.

Meaning: The part of a scene, photograph, painting, or view that appears behind the main subject.

Practice 1

> “There are mountains in the **background** of the photograph.”

「照片的**背景／後方景物**中有一些山。」

Practice 2

> “The building in the **background** is the old town hall.”

「**背景中**那座建築物是舊市政廳。」

background = 位於主要人物或物件後方、構成整體畫面的部分

2. **background** = less noticeable part of attention/situation (注意力／情況中較不突出的位置) — 背景; 次要位置

This is the meaning in your original sentence.

Meaning: A position in which something is still present but is not the main focus of attention.

Practice 3 — Original

> “Everything seemed to fade into the **background**.”

「周圍的一切似乎逐漸**退居背景**, 不再那麼引人注意。」

Practice 4

> “Once I started reading, the conversations around me moved into the **background**.”

「我開始閱讀後, 周圍的談話聲便**退居次要位置**, 不再那麼吸引我的注意。」

Practice 5

> “Her worries remained in the **background** throughout the day.”

「她的憂慮整天仍然存在, 只是**沒有一直佔據主要注意力**。」

background = 某事仍然存在, 但已不再是注意力或情況中的主要焦點

3. **in the background** = happening/present without being central (在次要位置持續存在) — 在背景中; 低調地存在／進行

Meaning: Present or happening without attracting the main attention.

Practice 6

> “Soft music was playing **in the background**.”

「柔和的音樂正在**背景中播放，並非主要注意焦點**。」

Practice 7

> “Several people were talking **in the background** during the call.”

「通話期間，有幾個人在**背景中說話**。」

in the background = 某人／某事存在或進行，但位於主要事件之外、不是焦點

4. **background = personal history/experience (個人過往經歷／家庭／教育等) — 背景；出身；經歷**

This is a genuinely different and very important meaning.

Meaning: The experiences, education, family circumstances, culture, work history, etc. that have shaped a person.

Practice 8

> “She has a strong **background** in engineering.”

「她具有深厚的**工程學教育及工作經驗背景**。」

Practice 9

> “The students come from very different cultural **backgrounds**.”

「這些學生來自非常不同的**文化和成長背景**。」

background = 構成一個人過往經歷、教育、家庭、文化或專業經驗的整體情況

Common combinations:

* **educational background** = 教育背景

* **professional background** = 專業背景

* **family background** = 家庭背景

* **cultural background** = 文化背景

5. **background = previous experience in a subject/field (某領域的知識／經驗基礎) — 專業基礎；相關經驗**

This is closely related to #4, but especially important in education and employment.

Practice 10

> “Applicants should have a **background** in finance.”

「申請人應具備**金融方面的相關知識或工作經驗**。」

Practice 11

> “You don’t need a technical **background** to use the software.”

「你不需要具備**技術方面的專業背景或知識基礎**也可以使用這套軟件。」

background in + field = 某人在特定領域累積的教育、知識或工作經驗基礎

I would treat this as a **specialized branch of the personal-history sense**, not a completely unrelated lexical meaning.

6. **background = context/history needed to understand something (理解事情所需的前因後果) — 背景資料; 背景情況**

Meaning: Earlier events, circumstances, or information that help explain a present situation.

Practice 12

> “Let me give you some **background** before we discuss the problem.”

「在討論問題前，讓我先提供一些**相關背景資料和前因後果**。」

Practice 13

> “The report explains the historical **background** of the conflict.”

「報告解釋了這場衝突的**歷史背景和形成原因**。」

background = 幫助理解目前事件、問題或情況的過往資料和前因後果

7. **background information (輔助理解的資料) — 背景資料**

This is a very common compound based on #6.

Practice 14

> “The interviewer asked for some **background information** about the project.”

「訪問者要求提供一些有關專案的**背景資料**。」

Practice 15

> “Read the **background information** before answering the questions.”

「回答問題前，先閱讀相關的**背景資料**。」

background information = 用來解釋人物、事件或主題來龍去脈的補充資料

8. **background knowledge** (已有知識基礎) — 背景知識; 先備知識

Meaning: Knowledge that someone already has and uses to understand new information.

Practice 16

> “Some **background knowledge** of biology will help you understand the article.”

「具備一些生物學**背景知識**／先備知識會幫助你理解這篇文章。」

Practice 17

> “The course assumes no previous **background knowledge**.”

「這個課程不假設學生已具備任何相關的**先備知識**。」

background knowledge = 在接觸新內容前已經擁有、可幫助理解新資訊的知識基礎

9. **background** = setting behind text/person/object (設計／螢幕／影像中的底層畫面) — 背景畫面; 底色; 底圖

In design and computing, **background** refers to the visual layer behind other elements.

Practice 18

> “The text is difficult to read against the dark **background**.”

「文字放在深色**背景／底色**上很難閱讀。」

Practice 19

> “She changed the desktop **background** to a photo of the ocean.”

「她把電腦桌面的**背景圖片**改成了一張海洋照片。」

****background = 位於文字、圖示或主要視覺元素後方的底層畫面、顏色或圖像****

10. ****background noise (非主要、會造成干擾的環境聲) — 背景噪音; 背景雜音****

We encountered this in the ****noise**** family, but because it is directly relevant here, it belongs in the ****background**** family too.

Practice 20

> “The microphone picked up too much ****background noise****.”

「麥克風收進了太多**背景噪音／環境雜音**。」

Practice 21

> “Noise-cancelling headphones reduce ****background noise****.”

「降噪耳機能減少**周圍的背景噪音**。」

****background noise = 並非主要想聽的聲音、但同時存在於環境中的聲音****

11. ****background music (作為陪襯的音樂) — 背景音樂****

****Meaning:**** Music that plays quietly while another activity is happening and is not intended to be the main focus.

Practice 22

> “Soft ****background music**** was playing in the café.”

「咖啡店裡播放著柔和的**背景音樂**。」

Practice 23

> “The video uses calm **background music**.”

「影片使用了平靜的**背景音樂**。」

background music = 在主要活動或內容後方播放、主要用來營造氣氛而非成為焦點的音樂

12. **background** = computing process/activity running without direct user attention (電腦背景運作) — 背景程序; 背景執行

This is an important modern technology meaning.

Meaning: A process or activity that runs without being the main task currently visible to or controlled by the user.

Practice 24

> “The app continues to run in the **background**.”

「這個應用程式會繼續在**背景**中運行。」

Practice 25

> “Several **background** processes are using memory.”

「有幾個**背景程序**正在使用記憶體。」

background = 電腦或手機中並非目前主要畫面或主要操作, 但仍在系統內持續運作的狀態

Common combinations:

* **background process** = 背景程序

* **background app** = 背景應用程式

* **background activity** = 背景活動

* **background refresh** = 背景更新

13. **background** = low-level natural/scientific level present before a specific source is added (科學上的基準背景量) — 背景值; 背景水平

This is common enough in science to be useful.

Meaning: A naturally existing or baseline amount of radiation, noise, signal, etc., present independently of the

specific thing being measured.

Practice 26

> “The detector recorded a low level of **background radiation**.”

「探測器錄得低水平的**背景輻射**。」

Practice 27

> “Scientists subtracted the **background** signal from the measurement.”

「科學家從測量結果中扣除了**背景訊號／基準干擾值**。」

background = 在特定測量目標以外，原本已存在的基準訊號、輻射或其他環境水平

14. **background check** (對個人過往紀錄進行查核) — 背景調查; 身分／紀錄審查

This is an important family extension.

Meaning: An investigation of someone’s identity, employment history, criminal record, qualifications, or other relevant history.

Practice 28

> “The company carries out a **background check** before hiring new staff.”

「公司聘請新員工前會進行**背景調查／過往紀錄審查**。」

Practice 29

> “The job requires a criminal **background check**.”

「這份工作要求進行**犯罪紀錄背景審查**。」

background check = 對一個人的過往身分、工作、資格或紀錄進行正式查核

15. **background** = supporting rather than leading role (次要／輔助角色) — 配角性質; 幕後位置

Meaning: A role that supports the main activity rather than attracting attention itself.

Practice 30

> “He prefers to work in the **background** rather than lead the team.”

「他較喜歡在**幕後／次要支援位置**工作，而不是帶領團隊。」

Practice 31

> “She played a **background** role in the negotiations.”

「她在談判中擔任了**較次要的支援角色**。」

background role = 支援主要人物或活動，但自己並非焦點的角色

16. **background** = people/extras behind the main performers (影視中的背景人物) — 背景人物; 群眾演員

This use appears particularly in film and photography.

Practice 32

> “Several actors were standing in the **background**.”

「幾名演員站在畫面的**背景位置**。」

Practice 33

> “The director added more people to the **background** of the scene.”

「導演在場景的**背景部分**加入了更多人物。」

This is really an application of the visual meaning #1, so it should not be artificially separated as a completely new lexical sense.

17. **background** = become less noticeable / put something in a secondary position (較少見動詞用法) — 使退居次要位置

Background can occasionally function as a verb, especially in technical or specialist contexts.

Meaning: To place something in a secondary position, or cause it to operate/be treated in the background.

Practice 34

> “The software automatically **backgrounded** the task.”

「軟件自動把這項工作**轉到背景執行**。」

Practice 35

> “The issue was gradually **backgrounded** by newer concerns.”

「隨著新的問題出現，這個議題逐漸被**放到較次要的位置**。」

This verbal use exists, but it is **far less common** than the noun/adjective uses. For normal learners, recognizing it is enough.

Important distinction: **background** vs **foreground**

These are natural opposites.

background

= the less prominent part behind the main subject

foreground

= the part nearest the viewer or most prominent in attention

> “The trees are in the **foreground**, and the mountains are in the **background**.”

「樹木在**前景**，山則在**背景／後景**。」

Figuratively:

> “Cost has moved into the **foreground** of the debate.”

「成本問題已變成這場討論的**主要焦點**。」

> “Other concerns moved into the **background**.”

「其他問題則**退居次要位置**。」

18. **foreground** = front/most noticeable part (前景／主要焦點) — 前景; 突出位置

Since **foreground** is the clearest family contrast, it is worth including.

Practice 36

> “A child is standing in the **foreground** of the photograph.”

「照片的**前景**站著一個孩子。」

Practice 37

> “Safety has moved into the **foreground** of public discussion.”

「安全問題已成為公眾討論中的**主要焦點**。」

foreground = 畫面最前方的部分; 或比其他事情更突出、更受注意的位置

Important distinction: **background** vs **context**

These often overlap when explaining information.

background

= earlier facts/history that explain how the current situation developed

> “the background to the dispute”

「爭議的前因後果／背景」

context

= the surrounding circumstances needed to interpret something correctly

> “You need to understand the comment in context.”

「你需要結合當時的**上下文／情境**來理解這句說話。」

So:

background often emphasizes **what came before**.

****context**** emphasizes the ****surrounding circumstances in which something should be interpreted****.

Important distinction: **background vs history**

**history**

= the events that happened in the past

**background**

= the relevant past circumstances that help explain the present

Not every part of something's ****history**** is relevant ****background****.

Important distinction: **background vs backdrop**

**background**

Very broad:

- * visual background
- * personal history
- * contextual information
- * background processes
- * secondary attention

**backdrop**

Usually:

1. a physical background behind a stage/photo; or
2. the surrounding setting against which events happen

> “The mountains provided a dramatic backdrop.”

「群山形成了壯觀的****背景景色****。」

****backdrop**** does not normally mean someone's educational or professional background.

Important distinction: **background** vs **setting**

setting

= the place, time, and circumstances in which something happens

> “The story has a historical setting.”

「故事以歷史時代為背景。」

background

= the less prominent visual area, or contextual/personal information behind something

They overlap, but **setting** focuses more on the environment in which events occur.

Important distinction: **in the background** vs **behind**

behind

primarily indicates physical position.

> “The chair is behind the desk.”

「椅子在桌子後面。」

in the background

often means either:

- * visually farther back, or

- * figuratively less prominent

> “She stayed in the background during the discussion.”

「討論期間她一直保持**低調**, 沒有成為**焦點**。」

So **in the background** can be strongly figurative.

Family-extension note

Following our updated Golden Manual, **background** has several highly useful extensions that deserve inclusion even though they are not all separate dictionary senses:

- * **background noise** = 背景噪音
- * **background music** = 背景音樂
- * **background information** = 背景資料
- * **background knowledge** = 背景／先備知識
- * **background check** = 背景調查
- * **background process** = 背景程序
- * **background app/activity** = 背景應用程式／活動
- * **background radiation** = 背景輻射
- * **background image** = 背景圖片
- * **foreground** = 前景／主要焦點

They all develop naturally from one broad conceptual contrast:

> **foreground** = prominent / central

> **background** = present but behind, secondary, or less noticeable

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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background — visual scene	位於主要人物或物件後方、構成整體畫面的部分
background — attention	某事仍然存在，但已不再是注意力或情況中的主要焦點
in the background	某人或某事存在／進行，但位於主要事件之外、不是焦點
personal background	構成一個人過往教育、家庭、文化及工作經歷的整體情況
background in a field	某人在特定領域累積的知識、教育或工作經驗基礎
background — context/history	幫助理解目前事件或問題的過往資料和前因後果
background information	用來解釋人物、事件或主題來龍去脈的補充資料
background knowledge	在接觸新內容前已具備、可幫助理解的先備知識
visual/computer background	位於文字、圖示或主要視覺元素後方的底層畫面／顏色
background noise	在主要聲音之外同時存在、可能造成干擾的環境聲
background music	作為氣氛陪襯而播放、並非主要焦點的音樂
background computing	並非目前主要操作，但仍在系統內持續執行的狀態
scientific background level	在特定測量目標之外原本已存在的基準訊號／環境水平
background check	對個人的身分、資格、工作或其他過往紀錄進行正式查核
background role	支援主要人物或活動，但本身並非焦點的角色
background — verb	把某事放到較次要位置或轉為背景執行（較少見）
foreground	畫面最前方或在注意力中最突出、最主要的位置

For your original sentence

> “Then, as soon as they put the headphones on, everything seemed to fade into the **background**.”

The exact meaning is:

background = 注意力中較次要、較不突出的位置；某事仍然存在，但不再成為主要焦點

So:

fade into the background = 周圍的聲音和其他干擾逐漸變得不明顯，退居注意力的次要位置，而不是字面上真正消失。